

BEFORE

The British mandate, which put Iraq under British administration, lasted from 1919 to 1932. The mandate was awarded to Britain under the terms of the Covenant of the League of Nations following World War I.

THE BRITISH MANDATE

Britain's controlling interest in the Iraqi oil business <<414 caused deep resentment among Iraqi nationalists, but Britain ensured that their oil concession continued post-mandate. During World War II the British prime minister, Winston Churchill, ordered troops into Iraq to safeguard Britain's oil supplies.

THE ARAB LEAGUE was founded by seven Arab nations—Egypt, Syria, Iraq, Lebanon, Jordan, Saudi Arabia, and Yemen—in 1945. Five years later, its members signed a Defense and Economic Co-operation Treaty.

SUEZ CRISIS

In 1956, the Egyptian president, Gamel Abdel Nasser, wrested control of the Suez Canal away from the French and British <<412–13. This encouraged Arab nationalists across the Middle East to push for independence. In 1961, Iraq nationalized the oil concession areas, ending foreign interests in the industry.

IRAN–IRAQ WAR

This conflict was triggered by a territorial dispute over the Shatt-al-Arab waterway between the two rival states. Iran's revolutionary leader,

Ayatollah Khomeini

<<442–43, was unpopular with both oil-rich Arab states and Western leaders, who he denounced, sanctioning the seizure of the US embassy in Tehran by militants in 1979. Saudi Arabia,

IRAN–IRAQ WAR

the US, and others sold weapons to the Iraqi leader **Saddam Hussein** (see right), who waged chemical warfare against Iranian forces.



American carrier in the Suez Canal

The Suez Canal allows transportation between Europe and Asia without the need to circumnavigate Africa and is of great strategic significance. In the image above, a US aircraft carrier is covered by a gunner in an anti-submarine helicopter as it proceeds up the canal.

The Gulf Wars

Conflict erupted in the Persian Gulf in 1990 when the United Nations moved to oust Iraqi forces from neighboring Kuwait. A military operation led by US forces put an end to the occupation, but concerns about Iraqi leader Saddam Hussein led the US and Britain to enter a second war in the Gulf in 2003.

On August 2, 1990 Saddam Hussein (see right) invaded the oil-rich gulf state of Kuwait.

The United Nation's Security Council demanded immediate and unconditional withdrawal, but Saddam, a brutal dictator who had recently appointed himself Iraq's "President for Life," ignored the UN and announced that Kuwait had become a part of Iraq. The US acted to avert the crisis with a show of strength, sending substantial numbers of troops to the gulf region. Many UN nations, including Britain and members of the Arab League (see BEFORE) followed suit. Saddam responded by placing captured foreign nationals of "hostile countries" at key strategic sites in Kuwait in the hope of deterring air attacks.

The First Gulf War

In late fall, the UN issued an ultimatum effectively authorizing the use of force if Saddam did not withdraw from Kuwait by January 15, 1991. He refused to comply. The First Gulf War began on January 17 when the US and coalition forces launched Operation "Desert Storm," attacking Iraq and Kuwait from the air. Saddam's response was to launch the first of several Scud missile attacks on the Israeli capital, Tel Aviv. As allied forces entered Kuwait, Iraq launched missiles on

Saudi Arabia, but was ultimately no match for the fierce military onslaught of Desert Storm. In late February, after five weeks of war, US forces took Kuwait City and US president George Bush announced a cessation of hostilities.

Saddam Hussein showed no sign of being humbled by his defeat. As Iraqi troops withdrew, they placed land mines around Kuwaiti oil wells before setting them alight. It was an act of pure defiance. The Kuwait oil fires burned for several months, causing massive environmental damage.

After the conflicts Saddam was faced with uprisings in the southern Shi'a region of Iraq and in the Kurdish north. These revolts were speedily crushed. The extent of Saddam's brutality toward his own citizens was revealed years later when mass graves

were uncovered. In the aftermath of the war, the UN agreed that Saddam could remain in power, but economic sanctions would remain in place until Iraq destroyed both its stockpile and its manufacturing ability of weapons of mass destruction (WMD)—nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons. Over the succeeding years UN weapons inspectors visited Iraq to check this disarmament process. Saddam frequently obstructed the inspections, moving and concealing weapons, and in 1998 ordered the inspectors out of Iraq. The US and UK retaliated by launching Operation "Desert Fox," a bombing campaign aimed at destroying Iraq's weapons.

The horrific terrorist attacks on the United States in 2001 (see pp.466–67) led to a decisive shift in US tolerance of Saddam's defiant behavior. In his 2002 State of the Union address, President George W. Bush declared, "I will not wait on events while danger gathers." The US was now prepared to make preemptive strikes against its enemies to combat any further potential terrorist attacks. Bush instructed the Pentagon, the US department of defense, to develop plans for war on Iraq. The US was supported in its plans for "War on Terror" by the British government, but there was grave concern



Outdated weapons

Coalition forces in the 2003 Iraq War had state-of-the-art equipment; but Iraqi soldiers had outdated Soviet-made arms such as this RPG-7V grenade-launcher.

among other world leaders about the legality of American intentions. Arguments focused on whether Iraq actually still possessed WMD. George W. Bush insisted that they did, and he was supported in this view by the British prime minister, Tony Blair. In September 2002, Blair released a dossier detailing the government's assessment of Iraq's military capability. It claimed that Saddam had the capacity to deploy chemical and biological weapons within 45 minutes. The reliability of the dossier was rapidly called into question, as it was revealed to be based in part on research written 12 years previously,

LEADER OF IRAQ (1937–2006)

SADDAM HUSSEIN

Saddam Hussein was born to a poor family in rural Iraq. In 1957 he joined the Ba'ath Party, and a year later he became involved in an unsuccessful plot to assassinate Iraq's then-leader, General Quassim. By 1972 Saddam had a major role in government. He became Iraq's leader and gradually took absolute power, using torture, violence, and coercion to subdue the population. He was captured by US troops after the fall of Baghdad and tried and executed for war crimes.



but President Bush continued to put pressure on the UN to sanction war against Iraq.

A second conflict

With events escalating toward conflict, the UN sent weapons inspectors back into Iraq in an attempt to discover the truth about Saddam's military capacity. In spite of the UN chief weapons inspector's appeal for more time to verify the facts, US patience had run out. On March 17 the UN was informed that the diplomatic process was over, and on March 20 the US-led coalition attacked

American helicopters in Kuwait

US gunship helicopters in the burning oil fields of Kuwait. The "scorched earth" policy was ordered by defeated Iraqi leader Saddam Hussein.

